GAUGING THE CONSCIENCE QUOTIENT

India's civic values exhibit stark contrasts across states—while some lay complete store by integrity and responsibility, others are marred by corruption and ethical ambiguity

Civic behaviour is the glue that holds a society together, shaping the everyday interactions that define the quality of public life. From respecting public property to extending a helping hand in times of crisis, the choices individuals make reveal the collective character of a nation. Through 12 carefully designed questions, the India Today Gross Domestic Behaviour survey attempts to gauge public attitudes toward honesty, social responsibility and adherence to civic norms.

The findings reveal a complex tapestry of behavioural patterns across states, illustrating both encouraging trends and concerning disparities in public conduct. Tamil Nadu emerges as a paragon of civic virtue, securing the No. 1 rank, followed closely by West Bengal and Odisha, while Punjab languishes at the bottom, ranked 22nd. This stark contrast underscores the regional variations in how Indians navigate their civic responsibilities.

The findings offer encouraging signs. Nearly 87 per cent of respondents oppose tampering with electricity meters. Change is visible on the ground: Aggregate Technical and Commercial losses for power companies—a key indicator of power theft and inefficiency—dropped to 15.3 per cent in FY23 from 37 per cent in FY05. Slowly but surely, social responsibility is gaining ground.

Yet, integrity frays when personal interests collide with moral considerations. A concerning 61 per cent of the respondents admit that they are willing to pay bribes to expedite bureaucratic processes, with Uttar Pradesh emerging as the worst offender. Public responsibility also exhibits stark regional contrasts. In an inspiring display of altruism, 99 per cent of the respondents in West Bengal say they would stop to help an accident victim, a figure that plummets to 22 per cent in Odisha.

Taken together, these findings suggest a nation in transition—one where traditional values of community assistance coexist with evolving attitudes toward digital governance and environmental stewardship, yet where systemic challenges of corruption and tax evasion continue to demand attention from policymakers and citizens alike. ■

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CIVIC BEHAVIOUR THE LEADERS AND THE LAGGARDS

RANK 2025	STATE
1	TAMIL NADU
2	WEST BENGAL
3	ODISHA
4	NCT OF DELHI
5	KERALA
6	HARYANA
7	MAHARASHTRA
8	UTTARAKHAND
9	HIMACHAL PRADESH
10	JHARKHAND
11	BIHAR
12	CHANDIGARH
13	TELANGANA
14	RAJASTHAN
15	MADHYA PRADESH
16	CHHATTISGARH
17	KARNATAKA
18	UTTAR PRADESH
19	ANDHRA PRADESH
20	ASSAM
21	GUJARAT
22	PUNJAB